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In the Doldrums

Statutory Meetings after ‘the Riots’

The enforced absence of VOC, the protest violence of March 13, and the charged atmosphere in the weeks following—all sucked the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company into a maelstrom. The management had to confront the dark clouds and face the high winds. The *Gallia* was laid up in Colombo, and only the *Lawoe* was sailing somewhat regularly. The challenges of running the steamer service apart, statutory requirements under the Indian Companies Act demanded immediate attention.

The immediate focus of the company was to distance itself from the protest violence of 13 March. SSNCo had to repeatedly aver that ‘The Company had nothing to do with the Tirunelveli riots of March 1908’,[1] and that it had no political axe to grind. After VOC’s exit, the directors urged, ‘we must particularly guard against the company incurring any official disfavour and we should also guard against it by keeping our company aloof from politics altogether’.[2] Though the compulsions underlying this disavowal were clear it could not have helped in any way. With ‘Swadeshi’ in its nomenclature, ‘Vande Mataram’ on its stationery and patriotism in its prospectuses it could not have fooled the government. On the other hand, such a claim would not go down well with the patriotic public whose backing was the cornerstone of the company.

Swadeshi was SSNCo’s oxygen, lifeblood, ballast, steam, its raison d’être. Its politics was a topic that animated discussion not only contemporaneously but even a decade after its collapse. This issue came up prominently when S.D. Krishna Aiyangar appeared before the Indian Mercantile Marine Committee in early 1924. Ironically, it was the Indian member of the committee, Jadunath Roy, who asked if SSNCo did not have ‘a political aspect’. ‘Was your company started with political ends or